

Class 9 English - Kaveri

Poem 3: Canvas of Soil

Detailed, Exam-Oriented Poetry Solutions

Poet	Maya Anthony
Form	Short rhyming poem; each stanza follows AABB rhyme pattern
Central metaphor	Earth/soil as a palette and garden plots as canvases; seeds as brushstrokes
Speaker	A gardener / an appreciative observer of gardening and nature

1. Poem Information

The poem presents gardening through the language of painting. The earth becomes a palette, seeds become brushstrokes, each garden plot becomes a canvas, and flowers become part of Nature's artwork. The gardener is therefore presented as an artist whose careful work brings colour and life to the soil.

The poem can also be interpreted allegorically. A garden can represent life: seeds suggest possibilities, growth represents development, seasonal change suggests the changing stages of existence, and the variety of colours suggests diversity and harmony.

2. Stanza-wise Explanation

Stanza 1: Earth and possibilities

The earth is described as a rich and deep palette. A painter's palette contains colours, while the soil contains the possibility of future life. The dreams of gardeners enter the soil in the form of carefully planted seeds. The seeds wait for spring, when favourable conditions allow them to grow and reveal their colours.

Stanza 2: Nature's work of art

When spring arrives, blossoms appear like a painting created by Mother Nature. Flowers seem to dance in the morning light. Green, red and blue create a vivid visual composition. Nature is presented as an artist whose artwork is continually renewed.

Stanza 3: Gardens as living canvases

Each garden plot is compared with a wide canvas where art and life meet. The gardeners' labour turns ordinary soil into a beautiful composition. The phrase 'paintings still' suggests a finished visual scene while retaining the sense that a garden is alive and constantly changing.

3. Important Vocabulary

Word	Meaning
palette	a board used by a painter to mix colours
hue	a shade of a colour
canvas	here, a surface or space for a painting
blossom	a flower; also to develop or bloom
vibrant	bright, energetic and full of life
coincide	to occur or exist together
till	to prepare and cultivate soil
brushstroke	a mark made by a brush; here used metaphorically for seeds
imagery	language that creates mental pictures
allegory	a work in which surface details express deeper ideas

Word	Meaning
diversity	variety or difference
renewal	the process of becoming fresh or new again

4. Poetic Devices

Device	Explanation	Example
Metaphor	A direct comparison without like/as.	"Palette of earth"; "Brushstrokes of seeds"; "Each plot, a canvas wide".
Personification	Giving human qualities to non-human things.	Flowers are described as dancing; Nature is presented as an artist.
Imagery	Words create vivid sensory pictures.	Colours, blossoms, morning light and shades of green, red and blue create visual imagery.
Alliteration	Repetition of initial consonant sounds.	"Blossoms bloom" repeats the /b/ sound.
Rhyme	Corresponding end sounds create musicality.	Each stanza follows AABB: deep/seep, true/hue; sight/light, blue/new; wide/coincide, till/still.
Allegory	Surface story carries a deeper meaning.	The garden can represent life, growth, diversity and renewal.

5. Check Your Understanding - Complete Solutions

Q. Complete the summary of Stanza 1.

Answer: The earth is portrayed as a rich palette where gardeners' dreams flourish in the form of seeds, awaiting spring.

Q. Complete the summary of Stanza 2.

Answer: The garden flowers blossom into a beautiful display of different blooms, resembling a painting by Mother Nature, in the light of morning.

Q. Complete the summary of Stanza 3.

Answer: Each garden is likened to a wide canvas, integrating art and life. Through the efforts of gardeners, gardens transform into still-life paintings.

Q. Give the appropriate title for each stanza.

Answer: Stanza 1: Earth and Possibilities. Stanza 2: Nature's Work of Art. Stanza 3: Gardens as Living Canvases.

Q. Match the poetic devices.

Answer: 1-iv: Imagery → colours, brushstrokes, blossoms, shades of green. 2-vi: Metaphor → garden as a painting, plot as canvas, seeds as brushstrokes. 3-ii: Rhyme Scheme → AABB. 4-i: Tone → appreciative. 5-vii: Mood → joyful. 6-v: Speaker → a gardener. 7-iii: Alliteration → 'Blossoms bloom'.

6. Critical Reflection - Extract 1

Q. Which option uses a metaphor like 'Brushstrokes of seeds'?

Answer: B. She has a heart of gold. The heart is directly described as gold to suggest great value or kindness.

Q. Why is 'planted true' significant?

Answer: It suggests that the seeds are planted carefully, sincerely and with genuine hope and dedication for future growth.

Q. Why has the poet used 'hue' instead of 'colours'?

Answer: 'Hue' is a precise poetic word for a shade or variation of colour. It also contributes to the musicality and rhyme with 'true'.

Q. Complete: Summer : hot :: Spring : ____.

Answer: vibrant hue.

Q. Assertion: Gardeners wait for Spring. Reason: Gardens are worth painting in Spring. Choose the correct option.

Answer: B. Both A and R are true, but R is not the correct explanation of A. Gardeners wait for spring because it is the season of renewed growth and blooming.

7. Critical Reflection - Extract 2

Q. What does 'Each plot' refer to?

Answer: It refers to each individual piece or area of land that has been cultivated as a garden.

Q. Which option imitates the rhyme scheme of 'wide/coincide'?

Answer: A. beautiful and clear / laughter and cheer. The end words clear/cheer rhyme, just as wide/coincide rhyme.

Q. Which line shows that gardening blends aesthetic beauty with natural growth?

Answer: "Where art and life coincide."

Q. What does comparing a plot to a canvas suggest?

Answer: It suggests that a garden plot is a creative space where the gardener arranges living elements to produce beauty, just as an artist creates a painting on a canvas.

Q. Why has the poet used 'wide' instead of 'long' in 'canvas wide'?

Answer: 'Wide' emphasises the breadth and openness of the garden space and suits the visual idea of a broad canvas.

8. Reasons for the Poet's Comparisons

Q. A painter is compared to a gardener because ____.

Answer: Both create beauty through deliberate, skilled and creative work. A painter works on a canvas, while a gardener works on soil and plants.

Q. A palette is like earth because ____.

Answer: A palette holds colours for a painting, while the earth holds seeds and the conditions from which the colours of a garden emerge.

Q. The brushstrokes are like seeds because ____.

Answer: Brushstrokes begin the visible composition of a painting, while seeds begin the living composition of a garden.

Q. A canvas is similar to a garden plot as ____.

Answer: Both provide a space on which an artistic composition is created; the garden plot becomes a living canvas through the gardener's work.

9. Analytical Questions

Q. How does the metaphor 'Brushstrokes of seeds' enhance the understanding of gardening as an art form?

Answer: The metaphor transforms planting into an artistic process. A painter places brushstrokes deliberately to create a picture; similarly, a gardener places seeds carefully to create a future garden. It makes gardening appear to be an act of design, imagination and patience.

Q. What does 'Each plot, a canvas wide, / Where art and life coincide' reveal about the poet's perspective?

Answer: The poet sees no strict boundary between art and nature. A garden is both a living biological space and a visual composition shaped by human care. Creativity can operate through living things rather than only through paint and paper.

Q. Does the imagery successfully create a vivid picture? Explain.

Answer: Yes. The poem uses palette, brushstrokes, blossoms, morning light, shades of green, red and blue and canvas. These details allow the reader to imagine the garden as a colourful painting that changes with growth and season.

Q. Why would adding yellow alongside red, blue and green strengthen the imagery?

Answer: Yellow would introduce another bright, warm colour and increase the visual variety of the imagined garden. It could suggest sunlight or yellow blossoms and create stronger contrast with green foliage.

Q. What does 'Gardens become paintings still' suggest about timelessness?

Answer: Although gardens change with seasons, their beauty remains worthy of contemplation. The artwork is 'still' in the sense of a still-life painting, yet it is produced by living, changing nature. Beauty persists through renewal.

Q. Justify the title 'Canvas of Soil'.

Answer: The title captures the poem's central metaphor. Soil is treated as a canvas on which gardeners create living compositions. Seeds become brushstrokes, flowers become colours and the garden becomes a painting.

10. Vocabulary in Context

Q. Give examples of shades of red, green and blue.

Answer: Red: scarlet, crimson, vermilion, blood red. Green: pine, apple, jade, olive, pistachio. Blue: navy, indigo, cobalt, denim, sky blue, ice blue.

Q. What does 'easel' mean?

Answer: A stand used by an artist to hold a canvas or board while painting.

Q. What does 'tonal range' mean?

Answer: The range of light, dark and intermediate shades used in an artwork.

Q. What does 'underpainting' mean?

Answer: A preliminary layer of colour or paint applied before final details.

Q. What is a mural?

Answer: A large painting or artwork made directly on a wall or ceiling.

11. Listen and Respond - Answer Key

1. Pink. 2. Jasmine. 3. Left and right corners. 4. 20. 5. White and red. 6. Peepal. 7. Bird houses.

12. Speaking Activity - Model Answers

Q. Would you prefer a flower garden or a vegetable garden at home? Give reasons.

Answer: I would prefer a mixed garden because it combines beauty and usefulness. Flowers add colour and attract pollinators, while vegetables provide fresh food. A mixed garden also gives children opportunities to learn about plant growth and responsibility.

Q. Give advantages of a flower garden and a vegetable garden.

Answer: Flower garden: colour, fragrance, beauty and pollinator habitat. Vegetable garden: fresh produce, healthy eating, practical learning and a sense of responsibility.

13. Writing Task - Model Answer

A Visit to a Beautiful Garden

I recently visited a well-maintained garden in the morning. Deep green leaves formed a background for scarlet, pink, yellow and white flowers. Some flowers appeared bright in direct sunlight, while others looked softer in the shade.

The textures were equally interesting. Some petals were smooth and delicate, while others were layered. Different shades of green appeared in grass, shrubs and tree leaves. The morning light made the colours look fresh and lively, and the arrangement of plants made the garden resemble a carefully planned painting.

14. Learning Beyond the Text - Model Project

Garden	Key features
Amrit Udyan, New Delhi	Formal gardens and seasonal flowers; associated with Rashtrapati Bhavan.
Brindavan Gardens, Karnataka	Landscaped terraces, fountains and illuminated evening displays.
Mughal Gardens, Kashmir	Terraced design, water channels and Himalayan surroundings.
Lalbagh Botanical Garden, Bengaluru	Diverse plant life and landscaped areas.
Government Botanical Garden, Ooty	Diverse plant life, lawns and a cool hill environment.

Mini-project: Students may select any two assignments as instructed in the textbook: research five famous gardens; analyse an art form inspired by gardens; design a garden; or interview a gardener/landscaping expert.

15. Additional Important Questions

Q. Why is the garden described as a living painting?

Answer: Plants grow, bloom and change with seasons, yet their colours and arrangement create a visual composition like a painting.

Q. What is the role of colour in the poem?

Answer: Colour makes the garden visually vivid and strengthens the comparison between gardening and painting.

Q. How does spring function in the poem?

Answer: Spring represents renewal and the moment when the potential contained in seeds becomes visible through flowers and fresh growth.

Q. Why is the gardener an artist in the poem?

Answer: The gardener selects, plants, arranges and nurtures living elements to create beauty, just as an artist deliberately composes an artwork.

Q. What deeper meaning can the garden have as an allegory?

Answer: It can represent life, growth, diversity, harmony, patience and renewal.

Q. Why is 'coincide' important?

Answer: It shows that art and life meet in the garden rather than existing as separate things.

16. MCQs

N o.	Question	Ans.
1	The earth is compared to a: A. palette B. brush C. frame D. sculpture	A
2	Gardeners' dreams are represented by: A. stones B. seeds C. clouds D. tools	B
3	The seeds are described as: A. brushstrokes B. colours C. canvases D. paintings	A
4	The flowers bloom in the: A. midnight darkness B. morning light C. afternoon storm D. evening fog	B
5	Which colours are explicitly mentioned? A. yellow, orange, purple B. green, red and blue C. black and white D. brown and grey	B
6	The poem's rhyme scheme is: A. ABAB B. AABB C. ABBA D. ABCD	B
7	The speaker is associated with: A. a gardener B. a sailor C. a painter only D. a musician	A
8	'Blossoms bloom' is an example of: A. alliteration B. irony C. simile D. pun	A
9	'Each plot, a canvas wide' contains a: A. metaphor B. hyperbole C. oxymoron D. pun	A
10	The tone is mainly: A. appreciative B. angry C. fearful D. sarcastic	A
11	The mood is mainly: A. joyful B. gloomy C. violent D. anxious	A
12	'Hue' means: A. smell B. shade of a colour C. sound D. shape	B
13	'Coincide' means: A. disagree B. occur or exist together C. disappear D. separate	B
14	The garden can be interpreted allegorically as: A. life and growth B. a machine C. a building D. a city	A
15	The title mainly compares soil to: A. a canvas B. a book C. a mirror D. a road	A

17. Exam-Oriented Answer-Writing Tips

- In a poetic-device question, name the device and explain its effect.
- In long answers, use the key metaphor: soil → palette, seeds → brushstrokes, garden plot → canvas, gardener → artist.
- Mention colours, morning light and blossoms as evidence of visual imagery.
- Remember that each stanza follows the AABB rhyme pattern.
- For analytical answers, connect the literal garden with creativity, growth, diversity and renewal.